
Summer Internship Interview Experience – American Express

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2023115093

About The Company

American Express (Amex) is an American bank holding company and a global financial services corporation specializing in payment cards. It leverages advanced data analytics, cloud infrastructure, secure APIs, and machine learning to deliver personalized experiences. A hybrid cloud environment ensures secure, seamless, and efficient operations. Amex invests heavily in fraud prevention, regulatory compliance, and customer engagement, making it a leader in the digital finance space.

Position: Technology Intern/Apprentice

No. of Applicants: 472

Students Selected for Interview: 16

Students Selected for Internship: 4

Out of 472 students who applied for the internship at American Express, only 16 were shortlisted based on their performance in an **Online Coding Round**. I was fortunate to be one among them. The interview process then comprised **two rounds – a Technical Round** and an **HR Round**, both conducted online.

Online Coding Round

1. **Largest Subarray Sum with Equal Ends** – You are given an array of positive integers. Find a subarray (at least 2 elements) where the first and last elements are the same. Among all such subarrays, return the maximum possible sum.
2. **Trash Collection Time** – There are N houses on a street, each storing bags of trash: Plastic (P), Glass (G), and Metal (M). Three trucks (one per trash type) start from the beginning, collect their respective bags, and return. Travel between houses takes given times, and loading each bag takes 1 minute. Find the minimum time needed until all trucks finish.

3. **Assassin Sneak on Guarded Board** – You have an $N \times M$ board. Each cell may be: empty ., obstacle X, a guard facing <, >, ^, or v (seeing straight until blocked), or an assassin A. The assassin can move up, down, left, or right on empty cells. Determine if the assassin can reach the bottom-right cell without being seen by any guard.
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Technical Round

The technical interview began with my self-introduction. The session mainly focused on Object-Oriented Programming (OOP) concepts and Data Structures & Algorithms (DSA).

Key Technical Questions Asked:

- What is a constructor and destructor?
- What is the use of the scope resolution operator?
- What is the use of the this operator?
- Explain the diamond problem. How is it overcome in Java and C++?
- What is the volatile keyword?
- Difference between malloc and new.
- What does malloc return?
- Use of the delete keyword.
- Types of inheritance.
- Operators that cannot be overloaded.
- Types of constructors. What is a copy constructor?
- Types of polymorphism.
- Static vs. Dynamic binding.
- Use of static keyword.
- Call by value vs. Call by reference.
- What is a friend class and friend function?
- Function overloading vs. Operator overloading.
- What is an abstract class?
- What is a virtual function? Difference between virtual and pure virtual function.

- Can we instantiate an abstract class?
- Can destructors be overloaded?
- What are access modifiers?

Coding Questions:

1. Array Problem: Given an array, return another array where each index contains the count of elements lesser than the element at that index.
2. String Problem: Find the first non-repeating character in a string.

I was asked to write the solutions in Notepad and share my screen.

Outcome: Out of 16 candidates, 10 were shortlisted for the HR round, including myself.

HR Round

The HR round was conducted by a Director of Software Development at American Express. The environment was friendly, and the questions were mostly resume-based and situational.

Key HR Questions:

- Explanation of my Machine Learning project (Hate Speech Detection) and justification for the chosen model.
- Why I used Bootstrap in my e-commerce frontend project and how I made the website responsive.
- Questions related to my awards and justification of soft skills like leadership, time management, and team management.

Situational Questions:

1. If you are on the way to catch a flight for an interview, but due to traffic, you can either break rules and reach on time or miss the flight, what will you do?
2. In a team project, if there is a conflict where two innovative solutions are presented, both equally good, which solution will you choose and why?

Personal Questions:

- Asked about my 12th-grade scores and whether I regretted losing marks.
- Resume-oriented discussions on achievements, skills, and experiences.

Candidate's Question to HR:

I asked, *"What skills should I develop to cope with the AMEX environment and contribute effectively to the team?"*

The HR responded:

"What I'm about to say isn't just for AMEX—it applies to every company. Always question everything. If you are asked to do a task, first ask why it is needed. Questioning is not a sign of doubt, it's a sign of clarity and ownership. This mindset is essential anywhere you work."

Outcome: Out of 10 candidates, only 4 were selected for the internship. I was privileged to be among them.

The internship interview at American Express was a highly valuable experience that tested both my technical knowledge (OOPs, DSA, Coding) and personal attributes (decision-making, teamwork, adaptability, and communication skills). Being selected among 4 out of 472 applicants was an achievement that boosted my confidence and reinforced my passion for learning and contributing to challenging environments.

Tips for Students

I started my internship preparation during my 4th semester holidays, but I strongly recommend you to start right from the 4th semester itself. Early preparation helps you build consistency and reduces stress later.

Here are some key takeaways from my experience that might help future aspirants:

1. **Strengthen Your Fundamentals** – OOP, DSA, DBMS, and core programming concepts are always tested. Don't just memorize; understand them deeply.
2. **Follow a Structured Plan + Practice Consistently** – I used Striver's A-Z DSA Sheet for a systematic approach and solved problems regularly on LeetCode to get hands-on practice.
3. **Solve at Least One Problem Daily** – Consistency matters. Even one problem every day improves your problem-solving skills over time.
4. **Be Comfortable Explaining Your Code** – Interviews often involve live coding. Practice explaining your thought process while solving problems.
5. **Know Your Resume Inside-Out** – Projects, skills, and achievements you mention will definitely be asked. Be prepared to justify your choices.

6. **Prepare for Project-Related Questions** – Even if you did the project yourself, you should be ready to answer any question about it. Anticipate questions and prepare in advance.
7. **Work on Soft Skills** – Communication, teamwork, and decision-making are equally important in HR rounds.
8. **Prepare for Situational Questions** – Think logically and ethically when answering real-life scenarios.
9. **Ask Good Questions** – Show curiosity about the company's work culture and values. It leaves a strong impression.
10. **Stay Calm and Confident** – Even if you don't know an answer, explain your approach. Confidence matters as much as correctness.
11. **Learn to Question** – As the HR said, questioning isn't negativity; it's about clarity, ownership, and professional growth.
12. **Take Every Interview as a Learning Opportunity** – Whether selected or not, each experience adds value to your journey.

Feel free to reach out anytime on LinkedIn :)

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